the Soviet Union or United States initiate a nuclear war, killing millions of the opponents and suffering in retaliation the destruction of millions of its own citizens? As Thomas Schelling has written, “there is just no foreseeable route by which the United States and Soviet Union could become involved in a major nuclear war.” Since choosing nuclear war would be, in effect, to choose mutual homicide, President Dwight D. Eisenhower concluded, “War is impossible…. there is no alternative to peace.”

Many observers find in the Cuban missile crisis confirmation for their belief that nuclear war is impossible. The crisis did not explode. The leaders who lived through that crisis felt what it was like to peer over the precipice. Since that time, both governments have exercised extraordinary caution about all things nuclear, circumventing interests in order to avoid fundamental clashes, cooling conflicts that might erupt, and discouraging the nuclear programs of other nations. Today, nuclear war between the United States and the Soviet Union *is* very unlikely.

But no event demonstrates more clearly than the missile crisis that with respect to nuclear war there is an awesome crack between *unlikelihood* and *impossibility*. Though many accounts of the crisis downgrade its risks (reflecting the widespread inability to believe that nuclear war could occur), Robert Kennedy’s memoir documents how close the United States and the Soviet Union came to making the impossible happen.

How could nuclear war have emerged from this crisis? An alarming number of plausible paths branch off the actual course of events and end in nuclear war. In order to aid the reader, we will summarize what happened in the form of a scenario and then spell out one of the paths that could have led to war. Actual events are represented by eight steps.

1. The Soviet Union puts missiles in Cuba clandestinely (September 6, 1962).

2. U.S. U-2 flight discovers Soviet missiles (October 14, 1962).

3. President Kennedy initiates a public confrontation by announcing to the world the Soviet action, demanding Soviet withdrawal of the missiles, ordering a U.S. quarantine of Soviet weapon shipments to Cuba, putting U.S. strategic forces on full alert, and warning the Soviet Union that any missile launched from Cuba would be regarded as a Soviet missile and met with a full retaliatory response (October 22).

4. Khrushchev orders Soviet strategic forces to full alert and threatens to sink U.S. ships if they interfere with Soviet ships en route to Cuba (October 24).